Chapter 12

Hard Work to Hardship:
North to North-East

THE NARCOTICS CONTROL BUREAU POSTING HAD STARTED TO BECOME somewhat monotonous for Kiran. There seemed no effort forthcoming from the NCB for initiating growth and development. The functioning was all 'closed door' with no attempt to make it transparent. Some of the top brass had prioritized their own foreign travel plans in order to attend conferences or seminars and kept whatever information they acquired there to themselves. Nobody else was given that information, so that only those who had it could stake a claim to follow it up by attending more conferences. The NCB director-general, M. M. Bhatnagar, wanted to keep the trips for himself but there were times when two conferences took place simultaneously and he could not possibly attend both. Bitterness among his subordinates had to creep in. However, there were amusing moments also when Kiran Bedi saw the chief receiving the invitations to conferences and recommending his own name for them on the files. The record of all such correspondence was kept strictly in his personal custody and no one knew the details. It was only when she would inquire about some inspector or the other, who was not present on duty, that she would be told that he was out arranging the visa and making travel reservations for the boss. Only then would it come to light that the chief was going abroad for a conference. Kiran rationalizes that the country does need to be represented at such conferences and that the head of the department is to a great extent the best representative. What irked her, however, was that whatever information was presented there, and whatever was acquired there, was never shared. As Kiran succinctly puts it: 'We only got to know about bits and pieces of it when the chief wanted to show himself off as the sole repository of all knowledge, and therefore most appropriate to continue to represent the country.' One can quite understand her frustration at that time.

Kiran somehow completed her two-year stint at the NCB and asked for a change, even if it meant going out of Delhi, and she did put in a written request to be sent out to the furthest place possible. Little did she realize the consequences …

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Mizoram is a part of the union territory cadre to which Kiran Bedi belongs. The state is about 2500 kilometres away from Delhi, and all the knowledge she had about Mizoram was what she had acquired from the weather bulletins over Doordarshan (the national TV channel) and the bamboo dances on Raj Path during the Republic Day celebrations. She had had enough of soft postings for a while and opted for a hard posting. She wrote to the joint secretary (union territories) that she would be grateful if she were sent to the Andamans, Arunachal Pradesh or Mizoram. There was no response to her letter and so she went to his office. She was assured that the matter was under active consideration and she would be informed soon. For quite a while though, nothing happened. She